



Early Career Teachers · Session 4

Learning Design

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems.

Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your school-day map. The design response comes after understanding.

Build it in from day one

The easiest time to build an inclusive classroom is before it exists.

Routines taught in week one

are easier to keep than routines changed later in the year.

Predictability helps everyone

including a new teacher who is still learning the school.

Your first habits

You are choosing them now, rather than changing old ones later.

'Day one' can also be the first day of next term.

Unlearning the ‘perfect classroom’

Some classroom habits arrive with the job. It is worth looking at each one again.

Worth keeping

Clear structure, warmth, routines taught explicitly and high expectations.

Worth questioning

Sticker charts and public behaviour displays, very busy walls, and whole-class compliance routines.

Ask of each one

What is it for? Who can succeed within it? What does it cost the student who can't?

Look at the practice, not at the colleagues who use it.

How this session runs

Short inputs, then doing. You design your own day-one setup, with a trio to help.

1

Start

11 min · Two inputs, then move

2

Brief

6 min · Trios

3

Options

13 min · Input, then choose

4

Universal first

7 min · Trios

5

Design

12 min · On your own, with your trio

6

Check

6 min · On your own, private

7

Continuum

7 min · Input

8

Gallery and commit

9 min · Whole room

You will leave with a day-one setup, checked against real students, and an asking list.

Regroup

Bring your school-day map from Session 3.

Move to the corner of the room for your setting:

A primary classroom

A secondary subject

Relief or another setting

Form a trio with two people near you. Each of you keeps your own two or three students in mind.

5 minutes

Keep your students in view

Hold a concise picture of each of the students you have in mind, including:

**Strengths, interests
and joy**

**Communication,
sensory experience
and thinking**

**What costs and what
lightens**

Identity and belonging

**What students,
families and the team
already know**

**Questions that remain
open**

You are not building a file on one child. Keep real, different students in view as you design.

Write your brief

Each of you writes a brief for your own day-one setup. Your trio helps you sharpen it.

On day one, my students will need to...

For some students, that means...

I could set up...

Check the wording: is it specific, workable and free from blame or deficit labels?

Options menu

Four short inputs. Listen for what might answer your brief.

1

Executive functioning supports

Match support to a known demand

2

Predictability

Clear information about routine and change

3

A schedule you refer to

Put up on day one and used every day

4

Visual supports

Clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate

Printed option cards are on your table. After the inputs, choose one or two for your setup.

Executive functioning supports across the day

Match support to a known demand:

Make the first step visible

Support holding or sequencing information

Make time and materials easier to organise

Prepare for shifts between tasks

Check usefulness with students rather than assuming the support works.

Predictability from day one

Predictability includes clear information about routine and change.

Help students answer:



**What is
happening?**



**What is
changing?**



**What comes
next?**



**What can I do if
the plan
changes?**

Give information early enough to be useful.

A schedule you refer to

A schedule can make sequence, timing and change more visible.

Choose a format the intended student can access, show where flexibility sits and make changes clear. Review the schedule in real use: does it reduce uncertainty and support participation?



Image placeholder

Does the schedule still provide useful information when the day changes?

Visual supports

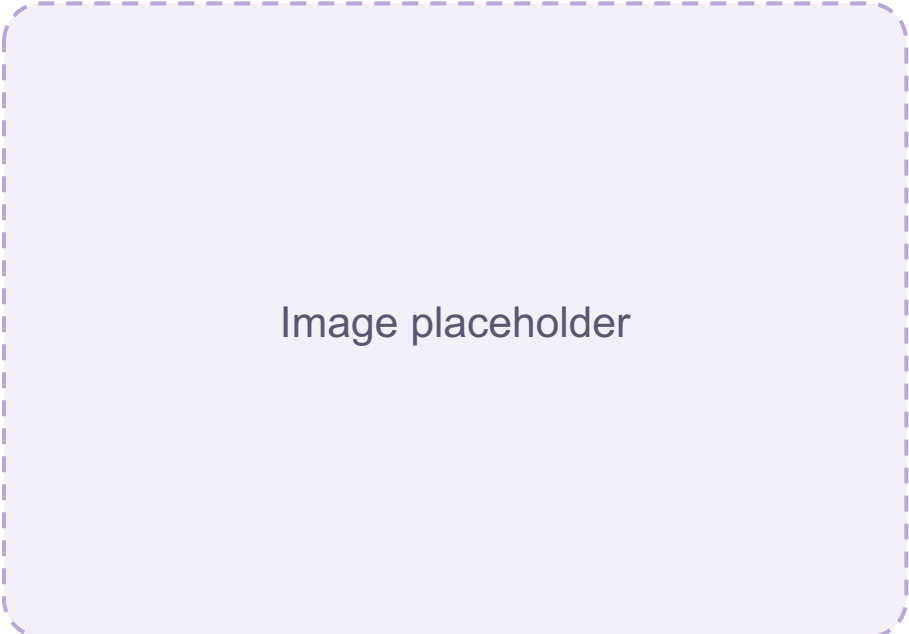
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Image placeholder

Visual Supports Checklist

Online webinar available to explore visual supports in greater depth.

A visual support should clarify something the student needs to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Keep it available at the point of use, avoid unnecessary detail, explain how it works and check its meaning and usefulness with the student.

Quick review of a visual support

- Can the student understand it?
- Can they access it when they need it?
- Does it reflect what is actually happening, including change?
- Does it provide useful information or a way to respond?

Choose your options

Which one or two options answer your brief?

☐

Executive functioning supports

Match support to a known demand

☐

Predictability

Clear information about routine and change

☐

A schedule you refer to

Put up on day one and used every day

☐

Visual supports

Clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate

Write down why the option fits: which demand in your classroom does it answer?

Record your choice, and why, on your A3 sheet, section 2.

Universal Design for Learning

Apply a Universal Design for Learning lens to the emerging design:

- Make important information clear and available
- Offer workable ways to participate and respond
- Support engagement without removing meaningful challenge

Individual knowledge and universal design can inform each other.



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Accessibility check

Run these over your draft design, then test it through use and feedback.

☐ Can students find and understand what they need?

☐ Can they take part in more than one way?

☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?

☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

Design your day-one setup

Three parts, then plan your check. Use your A3 sheet, section 4.

- 1 Ready for day one: what will be in place.
- 2 Builds across term one: what you will add or teach.
- 3 Your asking list: what you need help with, and who to ask.
- 4 Decide what you will observe.
- 5 Set a time to review.

Keep day one small. Ask your trio to check the setup remains student-centred.

Check the design against your students

On your own card, test your setup against each of your students.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

Continuum of support

Support is a continuum rather than a single intervention.

1

Inclusive environment

First, design inclusive environments that reduce barriers for everyone.

2

Universal supports

Then, provide universal supports that many students may benefit from.

3

Targeted supports

Next, offer targeted supports for students who need additional assistance.

4

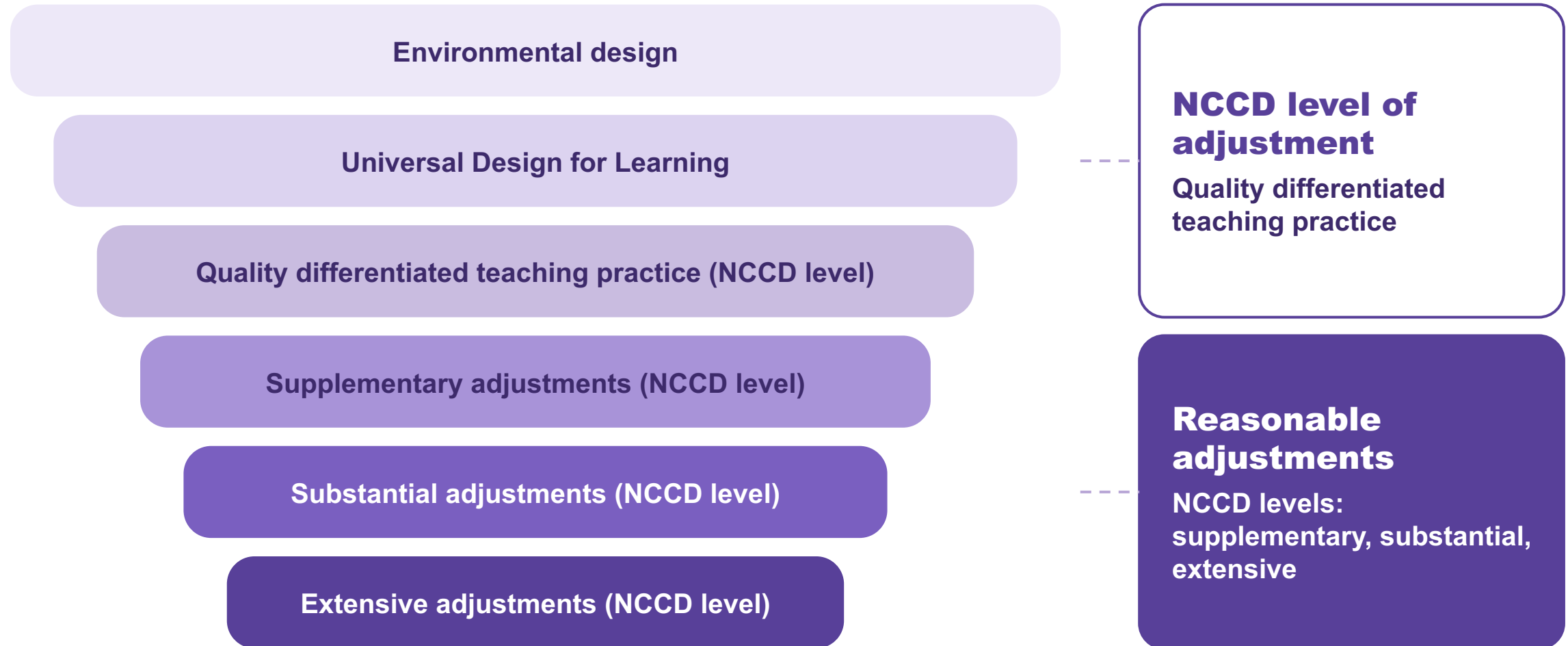
Individual adjustments

Finally, where necessary, implement individual adjustments to ensure equitable access, participation and learning.

Academic adjustments sit within a wider continuum of support.

Consider what is available to everyone, what is targeted and what is individually adjusted. Each response should connect to access and participation needs and be reviewed through use and feedback.

Reasonable Adjustments



NCCD

NCCD information and links

Connect the NCCD discussion with reasonable adjustments and evidence. Follow the consultation, documentation and review processes used in your school or system, and make responsibilities clear to the student, family and staff involved.

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Gallery walk

See what others have set up.

- 1 Put your A3 design on the wall.
- 2 Walk the gallery. On someone else's setup, leave a Post-it: one idea you would borrow, or one question.
- 3 Return to your own design and read what others left.

9 minutes, with commit

Share, refine and commit



After the gallery, ask yourself:

- What will be ready for day one?
- What will you notice?
- What is on your asking list, and who will you take it to?
- How will students and families help refine it?

Treat your setup as something to try, review and refine.